

THE CONSERVATION ALLIANCE

“This segment of the Ohio River Trail Council campaign focuses on the purchase of a sixty-nine acre threatened wild land for its habitat and recreational value. This picturesque area is located in the foothills of the Appalachian Mountains and is characterized by steep walls, wooded slopes, sandstone hills, and high rock cliffs. From ridges topping over 200 feet, there are breathtaking views of the deep Little Beaver Creek Valley below.”

Request for Proposal
Ohio River Trail Council
Proposed Conservation Area
Little Beaver Creek
National Scenic River
Ohioville, Pa 15009
May 28, 2011



ORTC REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL MAIN PROPOSAL

Little Beaver Creek National Scenic River Proposed Conservation Area Ohioville, Pa 15009

The Ohio River Trail Council (ORTC) is a registered 501(c)(3) that works to bring individuals, groups, councils, communities, businesses, recreational users and all levels of government together to promote and protect a continuous corridor of natural and cultural resources along the Ohio River and its tributaries. The ORTC is comprised of local municipal elective officials, interested businesses, property owners, and community residents. The ORTC's goal is to honor our past and build our future by providing recreation opportunities, heritage development, environmental stewardship, safe transportation networks and economic stimulus. Our mission includes the preservation and protection of the Ohio River Valley watershed in Pennsylvania for future generations. We aim to realize this objective through land acquisition and conservation easements, citizen education, historic preservation, and other environmental management activities that help to protect sensitive habitats and species.

The beauty of the Ohio River Valley is unmistakable. The valley presents with shady trees, cool creeks and an abundance of wildflowers and wildlife. The Ohio River Valley is located in a climatic transition area, where its water runs along the periphery of both humid subtropical and humid continental climate areas thereby displaying a diverse ecosystem inhabited by fauna and flora of both climates. French explorer Rene Robert Cavelier Sieur de La Salle was so taken with the Ohio River when he first laid eyes on it in 1669 that he christened it La Belle Riviere: The Beautiful River. Ohio is an Iroquois Indian name, Oheo, which traditionally is interpreted to mean "beautiful river". Thomas Jefferson stated: "The Ohio is the most beautiful river on earth. Its current gentle, waters clear, and bosom smooth and unbroken by rocks and rapids, a single instance only excepted." Over the last 150 years of industrialization, the Ohio River and its tributaries could have been more aptly defined as La Belle Couseuse: the Beautiful Sewer. However, clean stream laws over the past 50 years have helped the river make a comeback with reduced water pollution. This regeneration is reflected in the reappearance of aquatic life such as Smallmouth Bass, Largemouth Bass, Walleye, Shad, Channel Catfish, Bullheads, Carp, Stripers, and Trout.

The Ohio River Trail Council was established to build on this reclamation and continue the important work of protecting a critical local and regional resource that calls for enhancement. While many existing laws and programs now protect or encourage preservation of many resources and landscapes, there is a clear need to go beyond protection and preservation - to restoration of damaged critical habitats. The primary goal of restoration ecology is to return a community or ecosystem to a condition similar in ecological structure and function to that which existed prior to the site disturbance or degradation. The conservation and restoration of the riparian zone along the Ohio River and its tributaries is the cornerstone of creating a cohesive linear park and one that embodies the natural heritage of this important watershed. The Ohio River Trail Council encourages and supports the restoration and reuse of contaminated lands or brownfields using wildlife habitat enhancements. Both the environment and economy benefit if ecological enhancements are included in clean-up and restoration programs.

The ORTC proposes a multi-use trail along the Ohio River and its tributaries entitled the Ohio River Trail which will interconnect two of the largest trail systems in the United States, the Great Ohio Lake-to-River Greenway (GOLTR) and the Great Allegheny Passage (GAP) creating a continuous 500 mile mega-trail from the great lakes region to our nation's capital. The Ohio River Trail (ORT) when completed will enhance and further develop recreational opportunities for the communities along the ORT corridors as well as the region, by linking existing and proposed pedestrian, bicycle, recreation, open space, and transportation facilities. The ORTC through the development of the ORT will also protect environmental and cultural resources and improve public access to the river's edge. The ORT will serve as an important alternative transportation corridor between communities as well as reducing congestion and pollution. As a tool for ecology and the environment, the Ohio River Trail will preserve natural landscape, safeguard wildlife diversity and provide vital habitat corridors. This conservation will provide opportunities for birding, butterflying, deer spotting, fishing or enjoying the spring wildflowers or the peak autumn colors.

This segment of the Ohio River Trail Council campaign, nominated by Dick's Sporting Goods, focuses on the purchase of a sixty-nine (69) acre threatened wild land for its habitat and recreational value. This picturesque area is located in the foothills of the Appalachian Mountains and is characterized by steep walls, wooded slopes, sandstone hills, and high rock cliffs. From ridges topping over 200 feet, there are breathtaking views of the deep Little Beaver Creek Valley below. The parcel of interest to be conserved is located in Ohioville, Pa and borders the Little Beaver Creek which flows through some of Ohio's and Pennsylvania's most rugged and wildest lands and is located near the confluence of the Ohio River. Geologically, the valley of Little Beaver is extremely unique, being the only stream valley in the United States yet described, in which evidence of all four major glaciations is found.

The Little Beaver Creek with its numerous gentle rapids is protected by a number of classifications, including *Ohio Wild and Scenic River* and *National Scenic River*, as well as being part of Ohio's state park system. It is the only major river in Ohio to have dual State Wild and Scenic and National Scenic River designations. This designation covers approximately thirty-six (36) river miles. Little Beaver Creek ecosystem supports 63 species of fish, 49 mammal species, 140 types of birds and 46 species of reptiles and amphibians. The Little Beaver Creek watershed is home to Beaver Creek State Forest, Beaver Creek State Park, and Sheepskin Hollow State Nature Preserve. The flora of this area contains several interesting and unusual species. Canada yew, yellow and black birch, hemlock and mountain laurel can be found in the deep stream valley. The stream banks are lined with delicate wildflowers including jewelweed, hepatica, violets and spring beauties. Many types of wildlife find the varying habitats inviting. Red fox, skunk, raccoon and white-tailed deer are commonly seen while the elusive wild turkey is making a comeback in the area. Recently, sightings of black bear have become more frequent.



Hellbender Salamander



Bald Eagle Lock 57 Park
Ohioville Pa



Sandy & Beaver Canal Lock 54 Remnants

The Eastern Hellbender (*Cryptobranchus alleganiensis*) is a large generally 13-24 inches in length, completely aquatic salamander that is native to the eastern United States. They can reach twenty-nine (29) inches in length and weigh up to five pounds. Little Beaver Creek is also home to the Hellbender Salamander which is limited to a relatively few healthy stream systems, mainly in areas that have remained isolated from development and urbanization. They can still be found throughout their original range, but they are quickly declining in most places because many streams are not adequately protected from coal mines and sediment runoff. Hellbenders are especially sensitive to water pollution because they breathe through their skin. The good news is that there are still some very good hellbender streams remaining, mainly in Georgia, Tennessee, North Carolina, Virginia, and West Virginia. Several good streams also remain in some parts of Ohio and Pennsylvania. Ohio's largest population of the endangered Hellbender salamanders resides in Little Beaver Creek. The Ohio Division of Wildlife lists the Hellbender as endangered. Hellbenders are an important part of stream and river ecosystems. Scientists estimate that they can live for up to 30 to 50 years.

Ohioville's Lock 57 Community Park lies across Little Beaver Creek facing the proposed conservation area. In 1848, the Sandy and Beaver Canal utilizing the Little Beaver Creek linked the Ohio River with the Ohio & Erie Canal. Remnants of the once thriving canal system are well preserved throughout the region. The Lock 54 remnant is within hiking distance of the proposed conservation parcel. Lock 57 Park, Beaver Creek State Park, PA State Game Lands #173 and nearby Beaver Creek State Forest provide opportunities for where visitors can enjoy camping, fishing, horseback riding and picnicking. Stream fishing in the Little Beaver Creek is excellent for smallmouth bass and rock bass.



Lock 57 Community Park on right bank of Little Beaver Creek

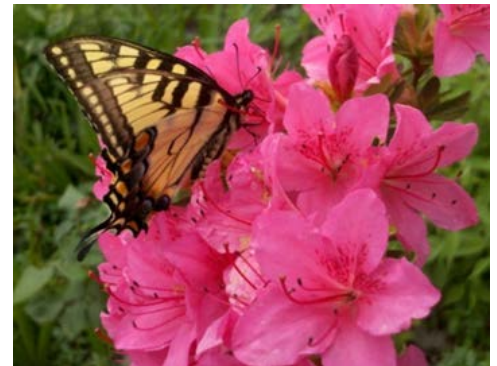


Proposed conservation area on left bank Little Beaver Creek



Little Beaver Creek (LBC) offers one of the most enjoyable scenic canoe or kayak trips in the state of Ohio and Pennsylvania. In addition to Greenways, Blueways is also a focus of the ORTC and the Little Beaver Creek is being established as a safe water trail for paddlesports. A Port of Pittsburgh Commission grant provided the installation of eight canoe or 16 kayak storage rack along with a ten bike capacity lock-it bicycle rack at the launch site. The racks support users who enjoy the pedal-paddle outings.

An ORTC grant from Venture Outdoors in conjunction with the assistance of Master Gardeners from the Penn State College of Agricultural Sciences Cooperative Extension is developing the ORTC Hummingbird & Butterfly Garden in Lock 57 Community Park. The ORTC Butterfly Preserve will provide a beautiful natural space open to the public. The benefits of a butterfly garden go well beyond beauty. It can also be a wonderful tool for helping to learn about ecology, native plants, and insect life cycles. Beyond that, the butterfly garden will help return native plants to the area, and preserve threatened species in danger of losing their habitats. With the help of the ORTC volunteers and the greater community, the Preserve will become a reality and a thriving place for native plants, wildlife and learning.

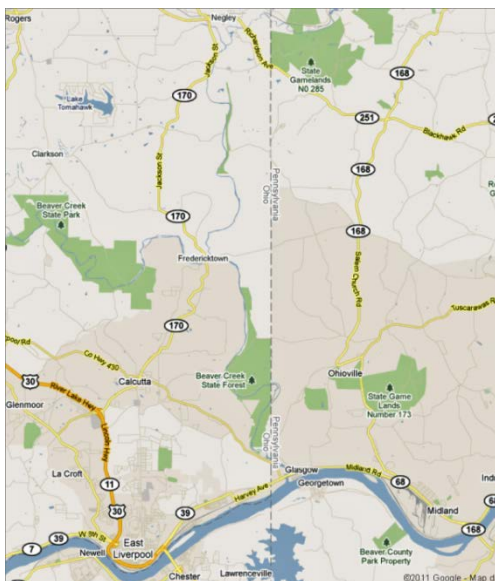
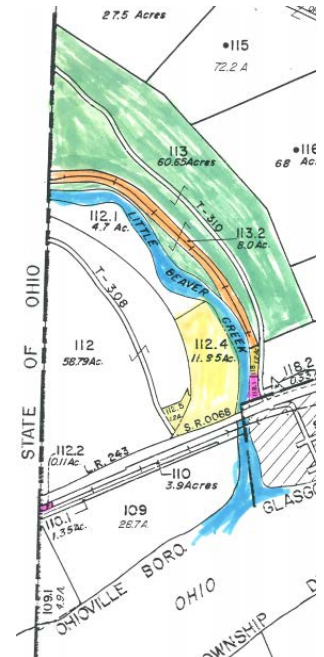


Swallowtail Butterfly

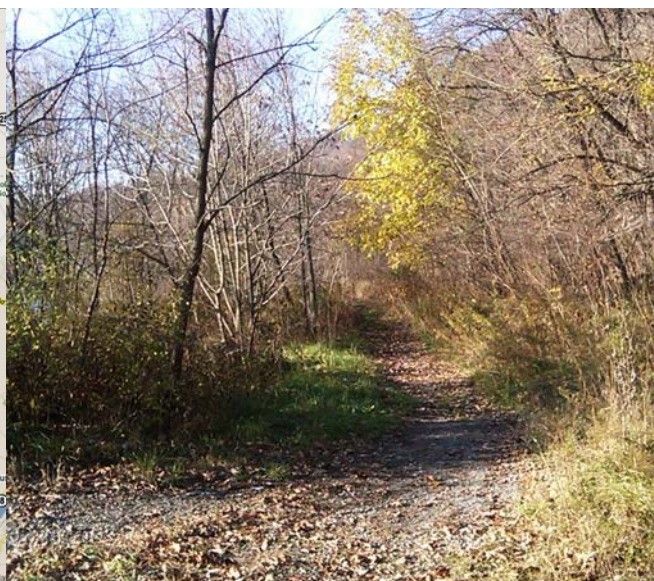
The Ohio River Trail Councils proposed purchase of a sixty-nine (69) acre tract of land in Ohioville, Pennsylvania is for conservation efforts and expansion of the Ohio River Trail. Located near the historic Point of Beginning, the targeted property for conservation (plot #113) is traversed by an abandoned railroad corridor (plot #113.2), the Smith's Ferry Branch of the Youngstown & Southern Railroad (Y&S RR). This passageway which also was the Sandy & Beaver Canal Towpath is the final link that provides a connection of the proposed Ohio River Trail in Pennsylvania to the Little Beaver Creek Greenway in Columbiana County, OH which is part of the Great Ohio Lake to River Greenway (GOLTR). The GOLTR stretches approximately 110 miles from the Ohio River to Lake Erie.

After the successful purchase of this property utilizing the Conservation Alliance grant, volunteers will begin conservation efforts to remove a dangerous coal shoot extending into the creek which has been the unfortunate site of numerous injuries and one fatality to curious explorers in this area. The illegal and hazardous disposal of over 600 plus tires has also been located along this stretch of Little Beaver Creek. Our goal is to remove and recycle the discarded tires to prevent possible outbreak of West Nile Virus. Located near the creek is an abandoned coal mine where the ORTC will begin reclamation efforts to completely eliminate the acid mine drainage. Not only will such a conservation effort result in greater water quality, preservation of natural habitat for birds, animal and aquatic life, it will eliminate health and safety hazards to those utilizing the area for recreational use including biking, hiking, canoeing, kayaking and fishing. The preservation of our natural resources and the health and safety of those utilizing our proposed trails and waterways remains a top priority with the Ohio River Trail Council.

In addition, the conservation of this property also supports the development of an eleven mile hiking trail from Lock 57 Community Park at the confluence of the Ohio River and the Little Beaver Creek to the North Country National Scenic Trail (NCT) at Sprucevale Lock in Beaver Creek Park. The NCT is planned to stretch more than 4,600 miles from Crown Point in eastern New York to Lake Sakakawea in western North Dakota. When completed the NCT trail will be the longest continuous hiking trail in the United States. The NCT is administered by the National Park Service (NPS) and is designed to provide peaceful recreational opportunities in some of America's outstanding landscapes. Lock 57 Community Park (Plot #112.4 & 112.5) may be expanded to include part of the conservation area from Tuscarawas Road to Little Beaver Creek.



Ohio & Pennsylvania
Regional State Parks, Forests & Gamelands



Youngstown & Southern Railroad Right of Way
Proposed Conservation Area

History abounds in the Little Beaver Creek Valley. A historic monument identifies the “Point of Beginning” located on the north side of the Ohio River near the three-way intersection of Ohio, Pennsylvania, and the northern tip of West Virginia. It is significant as being the initial point from which the U.S. Public Land Survey System was performed, starting in 1785, which would open what was then the Northwest Territory for settlement. The survey was “the first mathematically designed system and represented the first time land was actually surveyed prior to being sold.

In the 1950's, the historic “Indian Rocks” located in the adjacent parcel at Smiths Ferry, Pa were landmarks until dredging operations for the Stratton Dam at New Cumberland, WV, resulted in deeply burying the rocks, presumably never to be uncovered. Opened for traffic in Nov 1959, the Stratton Dam also increased the water level of the river by approximately ten feet. If the petroglyphs are not buried, unfortunately the water level will probably never again be low enough to see “Indian Rocks”. Before the dam was erected, the Ohio River was known to dry up at Smiths Ferry during the summer season and people traveled by horse and buggys from as far as Pittsburgh, Pa crossing over the dry river bed, to view the historical Indian site.



Point of Beginning Monument



Indian Rocks, Smith Ferry, Pa. Petroglyphs

The Lincoln Highway, named after our 16th president, was the first transcontinental highway across the United States of America. The highway was completed in 1915. The Lincoln Highway Route entered Pennsylvania crossing Little Beaver Creek near our project area and turned south on Main Street, passing under the Cleveland and Pittsburgh Railroad (PRR) into Glasgow. After passing through that community on Liberty Street, the highway turned north and passed under the railroad again at Smiths Ferry, merging with Smiths Ferry Road. This alignment through Glasgow carried the Lincoln Highway until 1926, when the present PA route 68 was built on the north side of the Pennsylvania Railroad.

